leadership was purged in the mid- and late 1960s, after which it was replaced by a group of PLA officers appointed and controlled by Kang Sheng and his wife Cao Yi'ou, an equally rabid ideologue. According to the CIA, it was not until late 1970 that a new kind of ILD began to take shape with the reappearance of several veteran members who had been missing during the Cultural Revolution. Shen Chien, a civilian who had been put in charge by Kang, was sidelined and, the CIA noted,

> Kang's own disappearance shortly afterwards left a leadership vacuum. This was filled by Keng Piao [Geng Biao], Peking's [Beijing's] ambassador to Albania, who returned in January 1971 and was named to head the ILD in March. During this period, the military presence which had dominated the ILD was reduced.[55]

The 'new' ILD emerged at a time when the Cultural Revolution was running out of steam, and more infighting erupted within the CCP. After the clashes with the Soviet Union on the River Ussuri in March 1969, Mao's then right-hand man, Lin Biao, was at the height of his power. He was the one who had initiated the publication of Mao's famous *Little Red Book* and played a dominant role during the Cultural Revolution. But then, unexpectedly to most observers in the outside world, he died in an air crash in Mongolia on 13 September 1971. What actually happened is still unclear, but in the official version of events, Lin Biao, his wife Ye Qun, their son Lin Liguo, and six subordinates were supposedly on their way to the Soviet Union following a failed coup attempt against Mao in China.

The circumstances of the alleged plot as well as the crash remain hazy to this day. The official Chinese version says the plane ran out of fuel. According to conspiracy theorists, however, the plane was shot down by a missile fired by either Soviet or Chinese forces. But a report on the crash compiled by Mongolia's intelligence agencies with help from Soviet experts after the crash suggests it was due to pilot error. The plane's three engines were not damaged before the crash, which would have been the case if it had been fired upon. The plane slammed into the ground at a speed of between 500 and 600 kilometres per hour, and the resulting explosion was followed by a fire that burned for a 'long time', the report said, suggesting there was plenty of fuel on board.[56]

It was at this time that the Indian intervention in East Pakistan, which led to the formation of Bangladesh, occurred—and it is worth noting that Islamabad got only limited support from Beijing in that conflict that was